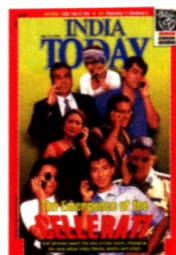
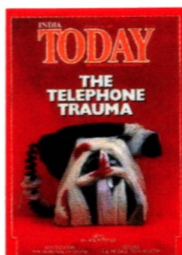


I CALLING CARD

Emerging from an era of telephone scarcity, we celebrated cellphone success

It was in August 1983 that INDIA TODAY had observed "To have or not to have a telephone? That is not a silly question." Then, the Connaught Place telephone exchange of 1935 was considered better than the one installed in 1975. "In the last six years, the number waiting for a telephone has more than trebled, from under two lakh to over seven lakh. Very soon it will cross the million mark." The situation was so miserable that "there are people who have been waiting for a telephone for as many as 18 years." Within two decades, however, the travelling salesman on board an overnight bus in Ajmer could be seen calling up his home in Delhi with his cellphone. In May 1998, INDIA TODAY stated, "With the number of cellphones touching a million in the April-June quarter, the cellphone era has dawned."



1983-1998

“It helps me monitor law and order while I am on the move.”

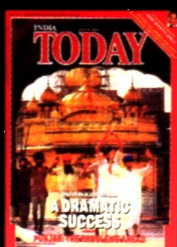
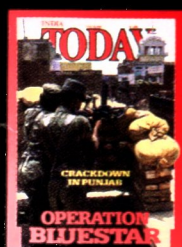
GOPINATH SHINDE
FORMER MAHARASHTRA
DEPUTY CHIEF MINISTER, 1998

THE PUNJAB ENDGAME

One operation opened the wounded, another tried to heal it

No decision could have more tragic than the one to launch Operation Bluestar in 1984. And yet, it was a denouement that was somehow inevitable. "For close to three bloody years, Mrs Gandhi's government had dithered as the extremist threat emanating from the Golden Temple had acquired monstrous proportions," noted INDIA TODAY in June 1984. Then, it was the world's biggest counter-

terrorist action undertaken. "For the first time in 400 years, the recital of gurbani was about to stop." What followed was a gory battle between the extremists and the state. The army's action had touched the nerve of a sensitive community and it took another four years for the trauma to finally end in the form of Operation Black Thunder. "In contrast to the messy Operation Bluestar which left 1,000 dead inside the temple, this operation was relatively bloodless," said INDIA TODAY in June 1988. "The terrorists of May 1988 were in no comparison to Bhindranwale's suicide squads. They had no cult figure inspiring them to fight." Punjab, however, needed another half decade to pull itself together.



1984-1988

“This was a fiery baptism. We didn't do badly.”

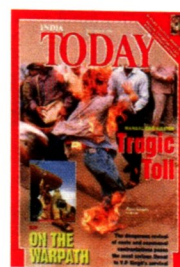
COMMANDO

AFTER COMPLETION OF OPERATION BLUESTAR, 1984

I CASTE IN CONFLICT

India was divided over reservations in education and it remained so over job quotas in the private sector

When V.P. Singh took a bite of the forbidden apple called Mandal Commission, he found himself in a situation in which he could neither swallow it nor spit it out. "The crisis, the likes of which has rarely engulfed the nation with such overwhelming intensity, was of his own making," said INDIA TODAY. Then in 1990, a Delhi University student, Rajiv Goswami, set himself on fire to protest against the commission. INDIA TODAY wrote, "The Goswami tragedy provided the agitation a rallying point. If Singh was obstinate to sticking in his position, it was because of his reckoning that the anti-reservationists were outnumbered by the reservationists." This was partly true, because most of the fire was in the north. Since the agitators belonged to the middle-class and could not keep up the momentum, the agitation did subside, only to burst with a new force. In May 2006, INDIA TODAY said, "In one swift move, the UPA has pushed the envelope further than even V.P. Singh did, raising the spectre of a divided India. Besides imposing a quota in Central universities and institutes, it is also pushing companies—some would say to the wall—for a jobs quota in the private sector. The move may be billed as affirmative action but it's actually aimed at garnering votes."



1990-2006

“If I have to choose between a cause I believe in and my chair, I will choose the former.”

V.P. SINGH

ON MANDAL COMMISSION, 1990